been for Deana and I to meet up. I had my back to the door of the club and was leaning across the table to make my shot. Suddenly I glanced up and saw the color draining out of John's cheeks. He was looking back over my head; I turned round to see Deana in the doorway behind me. The two of us went out into the car park so I could make my apologies, and that would have been that except, for some reason, I made the mistake of looking up at the first floor window of the club. Gary, Keith and John were standing there. I couldn't hear them but I could see their shoulders jigging up and down, the three of them giggling at the spot of bother I'd got myself in. I couldn't help myself: I started giggling too. I couldn't blame Deana at all for turning the rest of that day into a very long, very sorrowful one in the life of one teenage boy.

I have so many good memories of my times with Deana and also with her family. They were so welcoming: it was as if I just had to turn up on the doorstep and the next thing I knew we'd be in the kitchen; the kettle would be on, and there'd be something to eat on the way. It was very warm. Without making a big thing of it, Deana's mum and dad made me feel like I was part of the family. Her dad, Ray, was a Liverpool season ticket holder and I went to watch games at Anfield with him from time to time. Away from my own dad, I suppose I hooked onto Ray. He sometimes took me down to the pub. A couple of halves, of course, and I'd be rolling a bit. We'd wander back to the house together for some dinner. This was me really finding out about life as a man: out getting tipsy with my girlfriend's dad. It was a lovely time in my life and I'll always be grateful to Deana that she's never spoiled it. I know she's been offered money since by the papers to tell stories about me and always turned them down flat. I know that's because of the kind of person she is and I hope, as well, it's something to do with her getting a good feeling, like I do, when she remembers us being together.

Life in Manchester away from soccer was just part of what was totally new to me. There was this group of local lads for a start. Gary and Philip Neville, Nicky Butt and Paul Scholes were all from around Manchester, so they'd been training at United since they'd signed schoolboy forms, although they hadn't been at the vacation-time sessions I'd attended over the previous couple of years. I wasn't aware of it at the time but I think, to start with, they weren't sure about me at all: Gary says they had me down as a flashy little cockney. I can understand why. It wasn't because I was loud or anything but, when we were handed our uniforms, I'd always end up with the nicest tracksuit and the best-fitting boots. I happened to get on really well with the equipment manager, Norman Davies, and he just looked after me. I'd known Norman for a long time already from going to the games as a kid and, maybe, this was my reward for helping him tidy up dressing rooms for the first team